

liantly, and was cheaper by comparison. Businesses flocked to it and Mac market share fell further. Apple suffered a huge financial loss of \$68 million in that quarter. Spindler was dethroned and replaced by Gil Amelio, who saw a new, updated operating system as a key element to Apple regaining market share against Windows machines, but he finally gave up hope that the in-house development team would ever arrive at a finished product. He looked at three companies which could license their operating system to Apple—Sun Microsystems, Be, Inc. and, of all companies, Microsoft. Bill Gates saw this as a wonderful opportunity to outfit the Apple hardware with an operating system to get it going and squeeze out a signature on the intellectual property agreement that would give Windows the same charm the Mac operating system had. He admitted, “Apple is really good at human interface than we are.”

As these negotiations progressed, an engineer from Steve Jobs’ company, NeXT, called Ellen Hancock told him that NeXT had an operating system that was ideal for Apple’s computers. Ellen had the software checked out by a team of engineers and found it perfectly suited for Apple. They were ready if NeXT was. When the news was broken to Steve Jobs, he could not believe his ears. Overjoyed beyond control, he prepared himself for the sales pitch he would have to make in front of the Board of Directors at Apple. When the day came, he launched into an absorbing performance that was Jobs at his best. “If you think there’s something for you in NeXT, I’ll structure you any kind of deal you want—license the software, sell you the company, whatever you want.” Then came the main pitch: “When you take a close look, you’ll decide you want more than my software. You’ll want to buy the whole company and take all the people.”

The board was convinced and cast a unanimous vote in favour of Steve Jobs and the acquisition of NeXT. In late December 1996, Apple made an industry-shattering announcement that it would be acquiring NeXT, and that Steven Jobs would be returning to the fold as “special advisor.” Within a month of his return, Steve’s key